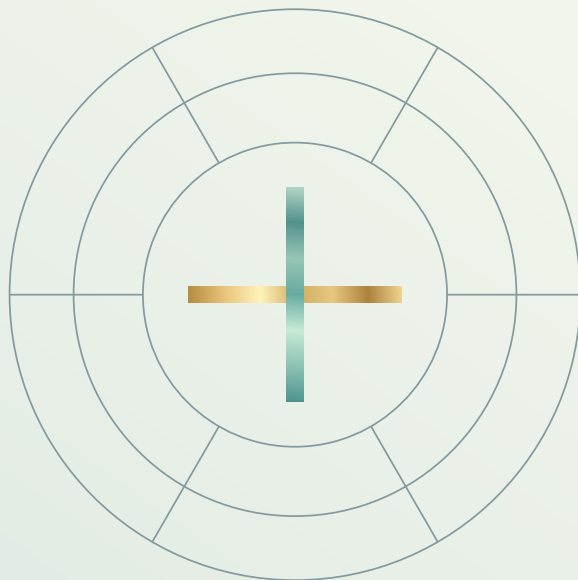


SWORD·WEAVE

Game Master's Guide

Prepare situations. Make clear rulings. Let choices matter.



MARIUS ION / v0.1 alpha / 11 OCTOBER 2026

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BEGIN WITH A PLAYABLE SITUATION

You do not need a map of a continent to run your first SwordWeave session. You need people who want something, a situation that will change if nobody intervenes, and enough facts to respond to the players' ideas. Prepare the pressure, then let their choices determine the story.

The Player's Handbook teaches the shared procedures; the SRD states them precisely. This guide helps you apply them: agree a ruling, review a creation, give a creature a purpose, prepare an encounter and keep a campaign moving. "Dungeon Master" and "Game Master" mean the same role here. You are also a player, with the world and its other inhabitants as your responsibilities.

WHAT TO BRING TO THE FIRST SESSION

Bring the shared rules, a way to record changes, the dice your table uses, and character records. Digital sheets are convenient; paper records work. Establish who can edit shared digital sheets rather than assuming that viewing permission grants editing permission.

Agree the starting budget and equipment, the tone, the expected length of play, and boundaries for content and interpersonal behavior. Discuss character concepts together. A group with a reason to cooperate gives the first scene somewhere to go. A 25-BU starting character is a default, not a promise that every newly invented power is accepted without review.

Optional guidance. Ask each player for a reason to help the others and a question they want the campaign to answer. Agree an easy way to pause or remove uncomfortable material without requiring personal explanations. Revisit that agreement as the game changes. This is table care, not a mechanical character cost.

Before play, check that everyone knows their current Vitality, applicable check bonuses, movement, reaction slot, relevant permissions and how their capabilities end. Do not require memorizing the entire Market. Ask a new player to explain one working in their own words; resolve ambiguity together.

A FIRST SESSION: THE GATE THAT WILL NOT OPEN

Original example adventure. The party reaches a canal settlement as water rises against a jammed sluice. Workers need the pressure released. Two Canal Watchers guard a spawning bed downstream and believe opening the gate will destroy it. A maintenance passage can bypass the stuck mechanism, but nobody has checked it since the last flood.

Tell the players what their characters can immediately perceive: brown water climbs the marked gauge; a rope trembles across the channel; workers argue on the bank; one Watcher gestures urgently toward the spawning beds. Begin with "What do you do?" rather than demanding a roll to notice the entire scene.

Prepare these facts, not a mandatory order of events:

Element	What you can reveal and use
Ressa, repair worker	Wants colleagues safe; knows the maintenance passage; will explain it to someone who asks
The Watchers	Want safe flow over the beds; can accept a credible diversion; use the complete record in Worked records
Gate mechanism	Jammed by a snapped timber, not magically sealed; accessible from the bank with suitable tools or a supported working
Maintenance passage	Narrow, wet and partly obstructed; offers another approach if inspected
Pressure	Visibly worsens as time and actions pass; give warning before a route becomes unusable
Outcome	Repair, diversion, evacuation, negotiation or force can change the situation

There is no compulsory sequence of persuasion, fight and repair. If the players recruit the workers, negotiate with the Watchers and divert a narrow channel, let those preparations matter. If they leave, decide where the water goes and which people need help next. The situation continues without requiring them to follow your intended solution.

TEACH THE FIRST RESOLUTION IN FULL

Suppose a character wants to identify the jam. First establish their approach and opportunity. From the safe bank, close inspection might make the broken timber obvious. If they must diagnose it while water shakes the mechanism, uncertainty and risk are meaningful.

Example ruling. You agree a Reason check, DC 12, to identify the jam before a support shifts. A player with Mental 3 and applicable PB 2 rolls 8: $8 + 3 + 2 = 13$. They identify the timber. They have not automatically removed it. Describe the useful fact and invite the next decision.

DC 12 is this example's agreed target, not a universal repair difficulty. If their displayed combined bonus is +5, use $8 + 5$ rather than adding the attribute and training again. If failure would not change anything and there is time to inspect safely, you may simply give the information. A die roll should answer a question the scene actually asks.

END WITH CHANGED CIRCUMSTANCES

After the immediate crisis, ask what the characters did about the beds, the workers and the broken mechanism. Those answers provide the next session's material. Ressa can become an ally; a damaged storehouse can become an obligation; an exposed old channel can reveal a mystery. A fight need not be the event that earns attention or progress.

Optional guidance. End the first session with a short review: *what was easy to understand, what slowed play, which rule needs clarification, and what each character wants next.* Agree rewards and new acquisitions with the table. There is no mandatory XP-per-fight or BU-per-session schedule.

MAKE RULINGS PEOPLE CAN UNDERSTAND

SwordWeave's DIY nature makes clear conversation more useful than a secret exhaustive list of legal actions. A player describes an outcome; you help establish what makes it possible and what matters if they attempt it. Keep the ordinary world available: a character can climb, negotiate, investigate or improvise without buying a primitive for every everyday act.

CHOOSE THE RESOLUTION QUESTION

Question	Suitable procedure
Is the result ordinary and secure under these circumstances?	Describe it; no roll is needed merely because an action occurred
Can one actor succeed against an uncertain challenge?	An agreed attribute/practice check against a DC
Whose opposing action happens first?	A clash, using actual timing and context
Whose directly opposed effort prevails?	A contest, using suitable approaches
Does an attack connect or does a recipient resist a working?	The chosen attack or saving-throw procedure; not both automatically
Does a creation permit the proposed behavior?	Read its access and limits before appraising execution

Use the relevant current attribute directly. Training adds applicable PB; expertise uses twice PB where granted. Opposing bias cancels one-for-one; remaining stacks add resolution dice. There is no imported automatic natural-20 success, natural-1 failure or critical multiplier. State any table variation before relying on it.

PRESENT THE STAKES BEFORE COMMITMENT

Say what success accomplishes, what the agreed uncertainty concerns, and what failure or Cost would change. A player can narrow or revise an attempt. "You can cross now, but the route is exposed; if the guard wins the timing clash, they can close it first" is clearer than revealing that restriction after the roll.

Separate access from effort. A water-shaping character may attempt a demanding diversion within their permissions. Paying a large Cost does not silently grant resurrection, mind reading or a new domain. If their idea needs a missing ingredient, discuss acquiring it, borrowing an actual source, choosing another approach or agreeing a clearly bounded Rule of Cool exception.

Optional guidance. If a failed check would only prompt the same unchanged roll again, advance time, reveal a different obstacle, offer another approach or simply resolve the safe repetition. Do not secretly convert every failure into a new penalty. Choose the stakes together when the scene can support them.

ORDINARY OBSTACLES AND UNUSUAL POWERS

A lock's material, mechanism, condition and accessibility matter. Ordinary tools may be enough. A metal permission may support reshaping a metal part; a precise internal modification may need a different verb scope from striking the lock. Creating a key, persuading the keeper and breaking the door remain separate approaches.

Targeting requires locating the target through an applicable sense. A player who cannot locate a hidden creature may propose affecting a known spot or area. They must accept the uncertainty that it is empty. Authored scrying, broad weather control or "any qualifying target within range" can define an exception; read its actual limits. Range alone supplies neither vision nor a targeting lock.

Projected workings travel through an actual path. Minor obstruction gives -2 accuracy; standard half cover -4; total cover blocks the trajectory. Direct manifestation does not use those intervening projected-cover penalties, but still requires valid targeting and access. Neither mode guarantees hitting someone whose location is unknown.

SOCIAL SCENES ARE ENCOUNTERS TOO

Know what each participant wants, fears and can reasonably offer. A persuasive argument can change their decision without supernatural control. A check can resolve uncertainty about an approach; it does not automatically rewrite every belief or remove another person's agency. If a capability truly overrides agency or information, its specific permission, recipients, resolution and ending terms need review.

Example. A Watcher wants the beds protected. Showing a viable diversion addresses that concern. Threatening it answers a different question and may create hostility. The same Influence bonus does not make those outcomes identical. A good proposal can remove the need for a roll if the response is already clear.

EXPLORATION NEEDS OBSERVABLE CHOICES

Describe signs of danger and resources that can support a plan: cracking supports, wind direction, an unstable floor, a route that is closing, a witness with partial information. Do not hide all useful information behind checks. A failed search should not erase something a character can plainly see.

Distance, time, terrain and supplies can matter without becoming a mandatory new subsystem. If the table wants a travel procedure, define what a decision covers, what is consumed and what constitutes progress. Mark that procedure as a campaign choice; do not present an invented ration tariff or weather table as universal SwordWeave law.

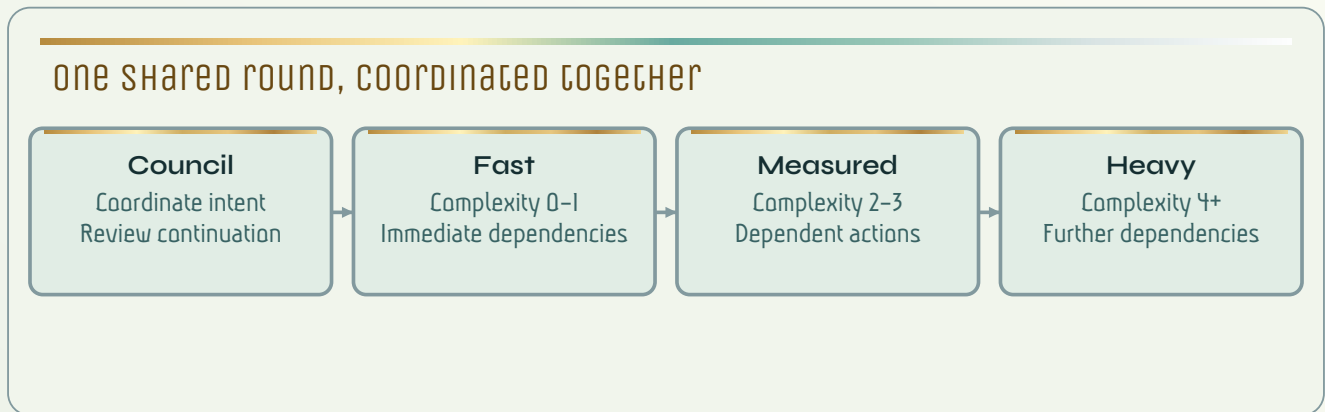
RECORD EXCEPTIONS WITHOUT BUILDING A TRAP

When Rule of Cool supports something unusual, record what made it possible. A Small character might wield an oversized sword with a three-slot requirement or an agreed restriction. That does not grant every Small character unlimited gear or imply a size multiplier for ordinary equipment slots. The fiction and explicit agreement explain the case.

If a ruling proves awkward, discuss a revision between scenes. Keep ownership, purchases and ongoing consequences understandable. Avoid changing a power's meaning silently while a player commits to using it. Campaign consistency supports creativity; it need not freeze an unclear first draft forever.

DIRECT A SHARED ROUND

Council then Fast then Measured then Heavy is a shared rhythm, not a row of personal turns. The useful question is how the participants' intentions interact. Make the opposition legible, let the party coordinate, then resolve the dependencies that actually arise.



Complexity places dependencies in the rhythm. Movement is one round allowance; a valid reaction pauses a moment without creating a new personal turn.

COUNCIL: ESTABLISH THE MOVING PARTS

Describe visible positions, immediate pressures and the opposition's apparent intent. Confirm ongoing requirements at their agreed continuation point, reset ordinary reaction availability for the new round, and gather the party's coherent Main Intent. Ask about dependencies: who needs a path, who supplies it, who might interrupt it?

Place actions by complexity: 0-1 in Fast, 2-3 in Measured, 4+ in Heavy. Complexity concerns dependencies, not simply the amount of damage or the BU price. A high-output direct action can be fast; a modest result with several dependent parts can resolve later.

RESOLVE INTERSECTIONS, NOT A CHECKLIST OF ISOLATED ATTACKS

Annotated example. At the sluice, Mira wants to divert a narrow flow; Neri wants to carry the snapped timber clear once the pressure falls; a Watcher wants to drive Neri away. The table places the immediate Watcher attack in Fast and the dependent repair in Measured. Mira's required preparation is made explicit before the repair can use it.

If Neri tries to reach the timber before the Watcher closes the route, resolve a timing clash where their opposing intents meet. Each rolls d20 with the suitable attribute, applicable PB and modifiers. Highest goes first; a tie is simultaneous or resolved from stronger fictional position as agreed. Losing timing does not erase Neri's entire intent. They can pivot to a different reachable approach if the changed scene supports it.

If Mira and the Watcher directly oppose control of the same current, a contest can determine whose effort prevails. The question is now force/control, not merely timing. Choose suitable approaches and apply the actual permissions and stakes. Do not call every opposed roll "initiative."

REACTIONS INTERRUPT THE MOMENT, NOT THE WHOLE ROUND

A default independent reaction has one available slot per round, a valid perceived trigger, immediate Complexity 0–1 and self/touch or a single target scope. Pause the triggering event, resolve the response and continue from what changed. Spending the slot does not guarantee canceling the event or create unlimited reach.

Example. Neri catches a worker slipping beside them. Their proximity and available hands support the action. Catching workers on both distant banks is a different scope. A separate authored grant may change reaction capacity or permitted behavior; it must be in the creature/character record.

MOVEMENT AND POSITION STAY CONTINUOUS

Use each participant's whole-round movement allowance. A Medium character with 30 ft can move 10 in Fast and 20 in Measured; they do not regain 30 because a reaction occurs. Ordinary swim/climb use half walking speed rounded up. Flight/burrowing need actual permission and speed.

Agree extra movement through an acquired rule or an appropriate Cost. Where the situation permits, movement may accompany an intent or occur independently. Positions should answer practical questions about reach, paths and interference. A grid is optional; consistent distances or zones with agreed translations can also work.

TRACK WHAT WILL MATTER NEXT

Record	Why it matters
Intent and track	Shows what is trying to happen and what depends on it
Position and movement used	Determines reach, available routes and remaining movement
Reaction availability	Prevents accidentally responding several times without a grant
Current / maximum Vitality	Distinguishes injury from the build's ceiling
Consequences	Records actual penalties, restrictions and their ending conditions
Continuing work	Records each capability's requirement and next continuation point
Objectives and environment	Shows progress, warning signs and changed options
Resolved markers	A convenience for the current round; not a permanent condition

Advancing a digital phase does not apply damage, expire effects or edit another player's sheet. Review actual endings before moving on. At the next Council, clear previous-round intent/resolved markers and establish the new situation. Keep consequences that have not ended.

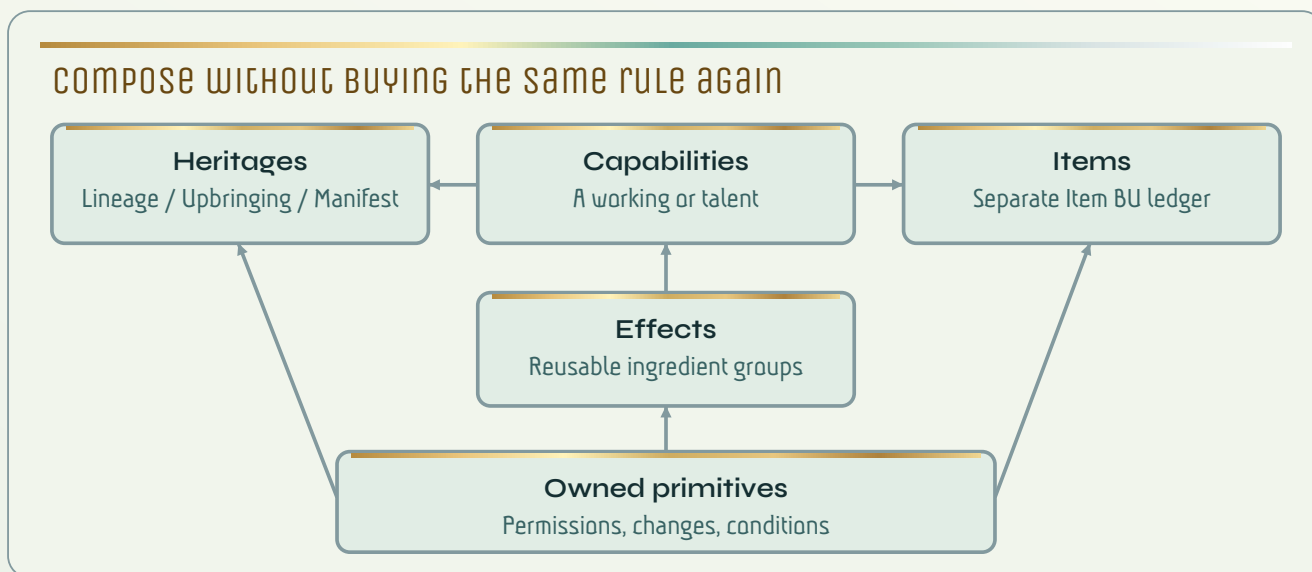
Optional surprise treatment. Prepared enemies may complete a round before surprised participants respond, depending on the situation or an agreed roll. This is a suggestion, not a compulsory surprise mechanic or an automatic reward for every ambush.

RESCUE IS PART OF THE SCENE

At zero Vitality a character collapses. A contextual rescue countdown—roughly a minute as guidance—creates urgency; it is not ten guaranteed safe rounds. Make the danger clear. Stabilization uses an action track, a suitable Fieldcraft approach or actual primitives, agreed resolution and Cost. No universal stabilization DC is prescribed.

Successful stabilization stops dying without granting healing or consciousness. Healing above zero normally ends dying and wakes the character unless another consequence prevents it. Active dying requires rescue before assisted rest. Massive damage can be outright lethal: establish those stakes in advance and use final post-defense damage and the current value before any zero clamp.

REVIEW CREATIONS AND CHOOSE CONSEQUENCES



Lines are references to owned acquisitions. A primitive can be used directly or through several containers; appearances do not create extra purchases.

SwordWeave gives players a construction language. Your job is to help the table understand what a creation does, how it fits the world and what a particular attempt puts at risk. An unusual idea is an invitation to examine the situation. Begin with the result the player wants.

Core rule. Establish access, actual scope, stakes, resolution and consequences before commitment. Let the player clarify or revise their intent. Apply the agreed outcome, then continue from the changed situation. The Rule of Cool supports coherent and exciting exceptions; state their scope so an exceptional moment does not accidentally become an unrelated permanent ability.

A REVIEW YOU CAN USE AT THE TABLE

Read a proposed component with its author. Ask these questions of the definition; do not make a player fill out a form to perform every ordinary action.

Review	What you need to understand
Result	What changes, who benefits and who or what can be affected?
Permission	Which owned ingredients support the change? Is any proposed behavior absent from them?
Conditions	When does it apply? What prevents it? What does a broad phrase such as “protected” mean here?

Review	What you need to understand
Composition	Which ingredients are actual acquisitions and which are references to purchases already counted?
Stacking	Do additional occurrences apply? Do sources share a uniqueness restriction? Is a grant being confused with another numerical bonus?
Use	How does the actor perform it, and what uncertainty requires resolution?
Continuation	Does it end immediately, last for a stated duration, or require maintenance? What can interfere?
Price	What suggested BU acquisition price fits this table's scope and restrictions? Keep Item BU separate.

An author's price is a proposal. Library and builder suggestions are useful comparisons. You may accept the proposal or ask for an adjustment, including a cheaper version if its limits make the original price excessive. Explain which part creates the concern. "It affects every target without discrimination or effort" is actionable feedback; "that sounds overpowered" leaves the author guessing.

Keep acquisition and execution separate. A purchased ingredient can support many uses without being bought again. A broad or hurried use can still incur Strain and agreed Cost. Buying another ingredient is one way to establish missing access; increasing effort alone does not silently grant a new behavior.

REVIEW a WATER-WORKING

Example. Mira owns Verb II, a Water domain permission, Near Range and d8 output. She proposes redirecting ordinary water away from a broken canal gate. Read the actual permissions. Check the water's quantity, distance, resistance and where it will go. Moving water is one question; creating a new permanent gate, locating an unseen saboteur or healing a wounded worker are different results.

For a small flow with time to work, you might agree negligible Cost and no roll. In a collapsing sluice, redirecting the whole surge before it reaches the workers is a demanding attempt. Make its reach, recipients, timing and stakes explicit. Mira can narrow the channel she controls, enlist another character or accept a continuing restriction instead of forcing the whole result at once.

Do not charge her again for the Water permission because it appears in both an effect and its parent capability. Do not assume the d8 ingredient makes every manipulation deal damage. Output applies when an appropriate authored construction and the proposed use establish damage or healing.

Write a consequence people can use

A consequence should change decisions at the table. It can be damage, a mechanical penalty, a restriction, lost access, an obligation, exposure, an environmental change or another narrative result. A number is useful where the result is numerical. An understandable restriction is useful where a number would hide what happened.

Core rule. Record the actual consequence, its cause, applicable timing or trigger and how it ends. A familiar name does not import another game's condition package.

Record	Example: holding the diverted channel
Cause	Mira keeps the surge diverted while the workers repair the gate.
Change	She must keep directing that channel and cannot use this working for a separate water manipulation at the same time.
Applies	While she continues the channel; the table agrees its place in the shared round.
Interference	Losing the necessary access or being unable to continue the directing task threatens it. A wound alone is not a universal cancellation rule.
End/recovery	The restriction ends when she releases the channel or the repair removes the need for it.

This is a possible ruling for this scene. It does not establish a universal one-capability limit. Several maintained capabilities can coexist; their agreed requirements and costs accumulate. Multiple effects inside one maintained capability share its one upkeep track and one Strain appraisal.

Contrast three possible costs before choosing one:

- **Mechanical:** an agreed amount of Vitality or a stated numerical penalty.
- **Restrictive:** hands, voice, attention or access must remain committed to the task.
- **Narrative:** the diversion floods a storehouse, draws attention or leaves a debt to the workers whose route is blocked.

These may combine, but piling on every category is not an automatic measure of fairness. Match the actual effort and scene. Offer a smaller scope or a different approach when a player dislikes the proposed trade-off.

Maintaining a working can spread pressure across time and generally be cheaper upfront than forcing a larger result in one execution; there is no compulsory discount formula.

Alpha rule pending — damage-triggered Vitality upkeep. Additional repayment triggered by incoming damage, including threshold and counter/reset/excess handling, is undecided. This edition does not impose that numerical scheme. Agree any temporary table treatment explicitly. Ordinary continuation requirements remain usable; this does not change non-Vitality upkeep.

BUILD CREATURES THAT CHANGE THE SCENE

A creature is useful when its behavior gives the party something to understand and respond to. Write what it wants, how it acts, what reveals its methods and when it stops fighting. A numerical baseline helps construct it; a purpose makes it playable.

CHOOSE A FOUNDATION AND CHECK THE ARITHMETIC

For positive creature budget B , use rank $r = \sqrt{B/25}$, base attribute points $\text{ceil}(3r)$, PB $1 + \text{ceil}(r)$, and baseline Vitality $\max(1, \text{ceil}(B/2))$. Allocate the available nonnegative points among Physical, Mental and Magical. Resolve explicit authored modifications after the foundation. Do not use the player's 10-point starting allocation or level Vitality formula for this creature baseline.

Creature BU	Rank	Attribute points	PB	Baseline Vitality
25	1	3	2	13
50	Approximately 1.414	5	3	25
100	2	6	3	50
225	3	9	4	113
400	4	12	5	200

Choose the proficient attribute and relevant acquired training. Check current values, practices, saves, DC, movement and senses. A high title or budget grants neither immunity nor extra actions. Give every ability its actual ingredients and readable behavior. The Canal Watcher record later in this book is complete, with definitions, totals, check bonuses and two useful workings.

GIVE THE CREATURE A SMALL READABLE REPERTOIRE

Optional design guidance. Start with one recognizable signature behavior, one practical alternate approach and a reason to change tactics. A creature that controls a passage and retreats when its nest is safe can create more play than a long list of nearly identical damage powers.

For each ability, record what it does, the eligible targets, access, range, delivery, typical expression, chosen resolution and ending/continuation terms. Its normal expression is a starting use, not an unconditional entitlement to any amount of scaling. If it has an additional action, reaction or special rhythm, write the grant explicitly.

ROLES SUGGEST BEHAVIOR, NOT HIDDEN BONUSES

Role	Useful question	Give the players a response
Melee pressure	What route or person does it threaten?	A visible approach, space to retreat or a competing objective
Ranged pressure	What path and target location does it use?	Cover, interrupted sight, movement or interference
Defender	What is it protecting?	A way around it, a motive to address or a limited defense scope
Ambusher	What does it know and how does it conceal itself?	Detectable signs and a consequence of revealing its position
Controller	What options does it restrict?	Clear scope, conditions and an ending or counter-approach
Support	Who benefits and what sustains the help?	A visible dependency the party can disrupt or negotiate
Solo threat	How does it interact with several coordinated intents?	Explicit action economy, readable tells and meaningful objectives

Do not assign a role and silently add a bonus. Actual mechanics belong in actual definitions. If a resistance applies only to Magical Fire, an ordinary Physical attack is not reduced by that label. If a transformation changes appearance, it does not automatically copy a target's abilities.

TEST THREE SITUATIONS

Before publishing, test the creature's ordinary use, a situation favoring its strengths and a situation exposing its limits. Check whether the proposed actions need missing access. Check quantities, Item BU, actual defenses, upkeep and termination. Ensure privately sourced dependencies are not exposed through a public template.

In the platform, preserve the selected immutable version. A template is reusable; a play copy records one creature's current state. Two copies of the same Watcher should not share damage or consequences. Updating the public template should not secretly rewrite an existing run's pinned content.

prepare encounters around CHOICES

An encounter is a situation with participants and competing aims. It can be social, exploratory, combative or several of those at once. Prepare what is happening and what will change; give the party more than one possible useful decision.

KEEP THE THREE QUESTIONS SEPARATE

Creature BU	Item BU	Execution Cost
Chosen base × quantity Build spent / remaining separate	Equipment × quantity Do not count it twice	Agreed for actual use Mechanical / restrictive / narrative

Appraisal multiplies chosen base creature BU and separate Item BU by quantity. Mirror credit is not another creature; execution Cost is not purchased again.

WRITE A ONE-SCREEN PREPARATION

Record a name, a short opening description, the objective/pressure, useful environmental facts and the participants' motivations. Add the chosen templates, pinned versions and quantities. Record Party BU and Party Item BU separately; party size is optional. Linked characters are a convenience, not a requirement.

Manual totals are the primary workflow. If you calculate from linked owned/shared characters, inspect each contribution and explicitly apply the result. Refresh on demand when sheets change; do not silently rewrite a saved preparation. A shared character's visibility does not give permission to change their gameplay state.

READ THE BUDGET COMPARISON HONESTLY

Enemy monster BU is the chosen base budget multiplied by quantity. Enemy Item BU is the resolved equipment budget multiplied by quantity. Do not add mirror credit as another creature budget, and do not count equipment in both columns.

Worked comparison. Two 25-BU Watchers with no equipment yield 50 creature BU and 0 Item BU. A party with 50 Party BU and 8 Party Item BU totals 58. Enemy combined total is 50: enemy minus party -8; ratio 50/58, about 0.86. With two party members, creature counts match. Each Watcher holds half the enemy creature budget.

These facts are not an “easy” rating. Water control in a narrow sluice, an exposed approach, an evacuation task or a successful negotiation can matter more than that difference. Look for concentrated output, control, area effects, support and burst opportunities. Comparable BU totals do not guarantee comparable difficulty.

CHOOSE A GROUP OR SHUFFLE ONE

Choose creatures for the scene's purpose, or use a suggested group as a starting point. If shuffling, specify whether a BU limit applies per creature or to the whole group. An optional separate boss maximum and Item BU limit answer different questions. Review the resulting group before accepting it; a random roster is not automatically a coherent encounter.

If the budget is missing, you can still save and run the scene. Omit comparisons you cannot calculate. If party size is unknown, do not pretend to know whether the enemies outnumber them. If a ratio has zero or absent party denominator, show the totals rather than a fabricated ratio.

OFFER PRESSURE THAT CAN BE SEEN

Optional preparation tool. Track a visible problem through a few named stages, such as rising, spilling and breaking. Describe what advances it and what can reverse it. This is a scene-specific clock, not an imported universal round timer. Tell the players about warnings before a consequential boundary arrives.

The sluice can rise while participants argue, spill after a support breaks and change routes when the walkway floods. A successful diversion can stop that pressure. Avoid advancing it merely because someone asked a rules question out of character.

START, RESUME AND CONCLUDE

Starting a digital encounter creates one independent private play copy per creature at the pinned preparation version. Repeated creatures get readable names. Resume continues an existing run; starting another run creates fresh copies and preserves the earlier one. Do not confuse opening a template preview with starting a run.

Conclude when the scene's practical question has changed or been answered, not only when all enemies reach zero. End the run while preserving the records. Deleting a preparation does not delete its playable copies. The template remains reusable; a new run need not inherit the previous creatures' damage.

CONSEQUENCES, RECOVERY AND CONTINUED PLAY

The review chapter explains writing a consequence. In play, keep its actual effect visible and give the player a way to understand its duration or ending. A dramatic injury, an obligation, lost access or an exposed location can matter without being converted into more damage.

MATCH THE CONSEQUENCE TO THE ATTEMPT

If the character strains to hold a beam, exhaustion or committed hands can fit. If they redirect water, flooding another area can fit. If they openly expose forbidden magic, witnesses or obligations can fit. These are examples; agree the applicable consequence before commitment rather than selecting a surprise punishment afterward.

A 0–6 Strain grade helps discuss the demand; it is not a compulsory Vitality invoice. Scale, impact, complexity, conditions, opposition and urgency matter. A normal use can have negligible Cost. Maintaining a result can distribute pressure instead of demanding the whole expression upfront, but there is no universal discount.

RECOVERY DOES NOT ERASE EVERY STORY

DM and players agree whether rest effects apply. A short pause may be 15 or 30 minutes; a long rest is overnight sleep or equivalent recovery, not necessarily eight hours. Time alone does not trigger healing.

The short-rest allowance is half maximum Vitality, rounded up, across short rests until a completed long rest refreshes it. Only actual healing consumes it. At maximum 13, allowance 7: healing from 10 to 13 consumes 3 and leaves 4 for a later rest. Long-rest healing is separate, normally to full; partial recovery may be agreed, and completed long rest still refreshes the short-rest allowance.

An injured hand may need treatment or a specified recovery condition even after Vitality is restored. A promise remains until fulfilled. State those ending terms rather than relying on a vague “rest removes it.” If a consequence is meant to recover quickly, say so.

KEEP MAINTAINED WORK UNDERSTANDABLE

Record each maintained capability, its continuation point, requirement and ending terms. One capability has one upkeep track even with several effects; several capabilities can coexist and their requirements accumulate. Loss of access until a task is completed follows that condition, rather than disappearing at the next Council.

A hit alone does not universally cancel a working. Interference requires actual access, timing and resolution. If the actor cannot perform a required task, they cannot continue it. A completed instant action cannot be interrupted retroactively, although its continuing result may be disrupted by a valid new action.

The numerical question of additional Vitality upkeep repayment triggered by damage is explicitly pending in the review chapter. Keep ordinary agreed continuation usable and do not silently impose an unresolved threshold.

BUILD ADVENTURES FROM WHAT PEOPLE DO

An adventure can be a short situation, a chain of related encounters or a region of unresolved pressures. Prepare the relationships that let choices matter. You can sell or share adventures while the mechanical framework and official playable options stay openly available.

A COMPACT ADVENTURE RECORD

Optional preparation format. Write the premise, three people/groups with aims, a few useful locations, an opening pressure, clues to the actual situation and possible changes if nobody acts. List any necessary component definitions or platform collection links. Include the definitions needed offline rather than forcing a reader to purchase another book to use a mechanical option.

For the canal adventure, a merchant wants the route reopened, a river community wants the spawning beds safe and a repair crew wants reliable support. Their aims can align or conflict. The old channel, damaged sluice and settlement storehouse connect those aims. An adventure grows from which relationship the party changes first.

REVEAL INFORMATION THROUGH SEVERAL APPROACHES

If understanding the cause is important, make it discoverable through more than one sensible route: inspection, a witness, physical evidence or an appropriate working. A clue should provide something actionable, not merely announce that another clue exists. A missed check can change the route or stakes without making the entire story unreachable.

Do not promise that every method gives identical detail. Tremorsense, a witness and a document can provide different useful facts. Extraordinary knowledge still needs its actual permission. A high roll does not invent access that the approach never supplied.

LET OUTCOMES LEAVE DIFFERENT WORLDS

If the party repairs the sluice with the Watchers' help, the settlement gains allies. If they evacuate and abandon it, the route may remain closed. If they destroy the Watchers and release the pressure, the spawning beds may be harmed. These possibilities are not prewritten ending gates; they explain how the world responds to actual choices.

Optional guidance. Prepare the next scene from the unresolved consequences, not by restoring the original situation so that your planned fight still occurs. Ask players which thread interests them. A campaign can follow their growing creations and relationships as much as a published plot.

REWARDS AND LONG CAMPAIGNS

Agree advancement pacing and BU awards. No compulsory class table, spell list or encounter XP formula is required. Spending BU buys acquisitions without undoing level progression. Keep equipment BU separate. At higher levels use the literal cumulative thresholds and continuing bracket procedure, not an improvised +IQ-only replacement.

Invite players to author or refine abilities between sessions. Review the same questions as at creation: scope, recipients, conditions, stacking, actual purchases and Costs in use. Check mirrored drawbacks rather than treating the debt ceiling as automatic free credit. A campaign's changing fiction can support a new heritage, obligation, training or capability without forcing a class label.

PUBLISH REUSABLE material CLEARLY

Distinguish an original definition from a reused ingredient and keep provenance/version references. Public creations need publicly accessible dependencies; a private source should not leak through a published record. Public, followers-only and private visibility describe access to content, not new ownership or gameplay editing rights.

For compatible publications based on SwordWeave's openly licensed text, credit the system, link the license and identify changes. You may sell your own compatible work under the applicable licenses without paying a SwordWeave royalty. Clearly separate your original protected adventure text/art from openly designated mechanical material. Do not imply official endorsement or use another creator's assets without permission.

PUBLIC SAMPLE ENCOUNTERS

The platform includes **30 original System encounter preparations**, three for each of ten bestiary environments. Their creatures are pinned to public definitions; their party budgets are editable references, never difficulty ratings. The books' offline sluice example remains usable without these links.

Explore the [public sample encounter collection](#) or the [public encounter catalogue](#).

- [Caravan at the Rooted Ford](#): a first-session crossing, 100 creature BU and 0 Item BU.
- [Voices Over the Sinkhole](#): rescue and unstable terrain, 400 creature BU and 0 Item BU.
- [A Debt Before the Last Gate](#): negotiation under pressure, 1,150 creature BU and 10 Item BU.

Read the opening, objectives, terrain, tactics, alternative approaches and consequences before using a roster. Adopt or clone a preparation into your account when useful; it does not grant editing permission to someone else's live sheets.

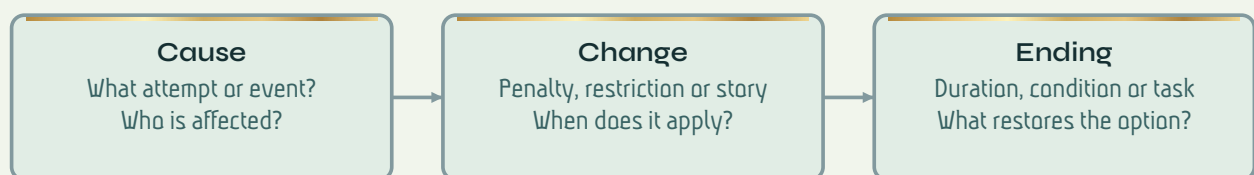
PRINTABLE PREPARATION TOOLS

These compact forms are optional aids. Complete only the fields useful for your scene. They describe your decisions; they do not create new mandatory mechanics.

ENCOUNTER WORKSHEET

Field	Your preparation
Situation and opening image	What can the participants immediately perceive?
Objective and pressure	What do people want, and what changes if nobody acts?
Party reference	Party BU; Party Item BU; optional size; linked sheets if useful
Opposition	Names; chosen base BU; Item BU; quantities; pinned versions
Budget appraisal	Separate totals; combined difference/ratio if calculable; count and concentration
Environment	Distances; paths; cover; available resources; visible warnings
Tactical notes	Control, area effects, support, burst, dependencies and counter-approaches
Alternatives	Negotiation, escape, repair, diversion or another plausible objective
Aftermath	What relationships, consequences and places change?

A CONSEQUENCE SHOULD ANSWER THREE QUESTIONS



Record the actual change and when it applies. A familiar condition name imports no automatic package; ending and recovery are explicit.

consequence worksheet

Field	Record
Cause	The attempt, event or agreement that created it
Actual change	Numerical effect, restriction, loss of access or narrative result
Recipient and scope	Exactly who/what is affected and what remains possible
Timing	When it applies, recurs or can be triggered
Ending or recovery	A duration, task, condition or agreed procedure
Owner of the record	Who keeps it visible and updates authorized state?

BETWEEN-SESSION REVIEW

Ask what the group accomplished, what remains unresolved, which costs or continuing effects still apply, and what each player wants to pursue. Check acquisitions, mirrored drawbacks, Item BU and pending rules changes together. Save the records and their versions so the next session begins from the world you actually created.

You have enough to run a game when the participants understand their characters, the situation offers useful choices, and the table can agree and record an attempt. The purpose of the tools is to support that conversation and the story that follows it.

Worked records and table references

The following constructions reproduce their ingredients so they can be used without a live catalogue. They are examples, not additional mandatory character choices. Acquisition costs use the reference anchors; execution stakes remain contextual.

Mira: a complete starting character

Concept. Mira grew up repairing canal boats. She wants to reopen the abandoned trade route and discover why the river no longer follows its old course. She knows the work of water better than court etiquette and needs companions who can help her reach the old locks.

Field	Starting record
Foundation	Level I; 25 character BU; Medium size
Base attributes	Physical 3, Mental 3, Magical 4: total 10
Proficient attribute	Magical; baseline PB 2
Extra training	Knowledge proficiency
Vitality	Maximum 12; current 12
Short-rest allowance	6 remaining until a completed long rest refreshes it
DC	$5 + 2 + 4 = 11$, using Magical
Movement	Walking 30 ft per round; ordinary swim/climb 15 ft
Equipment	Six equipped slots; capacity $40 + 5 \times 3 = 55$ Load
Acquisition	24 spent; 1 unspent; no mirrored credit

Her practices use the full parent attribute. Prowess, Finesse and Fieldcraft are +3; Awareness, Reason and Influence +3; Knowledge +5; Mysticism, Communion and Intuition +6. Those are combined check bonuses, not numbers to which the same attribute and PB are added again. Saving throws are separate: +3 Physical, +3 Mental and +6 Magical. The chosen proficient Magical attribute supplies PB to its saving throw as well as its practices; further grants and direct modifiers follow their actual scope.

Acquired primitive	Bound definition	BU
Verb Access II	Permission to change existing states/properties within owned domain access: reshape, redirect, combine, separate, transfer or stabilize	8
Water Domain I	Grounded water is an eligible subject; no permission to control every grounded domain or abstract meaning of water	4
Near Range	Permit eligible workings up to 30 ft; use actual target location and path	4
d8 Output	Permit d8 output in an appropriate damage/healing construction; no automatic number of dice or new behavior	4
Knowledge Proficiency	Add PB to applicable Knowledge checks where that training is not already supplied	4

River Caravan Upbringing organizes Verb II, Water I and Knowledge proficiency: 16 BU of the existing ledger. It describes canal work, communal repairs and the habit of asking where a current will go. It does not add a second charge for those acquisitions.

Guided Water, an effect. References Verb II, Water I and Near Range. It permits guiding or reshaping existing grounded water that Mira can locate within 30 ft. Define the actual volume, route and opposition for the attempted use. It supplies neither an invisible-target lock nor unconditional control of every flow.

River Hand, a capability. Uses Guided Water to redirect streams or transfer water between vessels. Ordinary small tasks can need no roll or meaningful Cost. A surging canal may require resolution, more time, help or agreed consequences. Duration and upkeep are agreed for the actual working. The d8 acquisition can support a separately defined water impact; River Hand's description alone is not a healing power.

Sample use. Mira diverts a narrow stream from a worker's legs. The table agrees that reshaping the existing water is within access; the worker is visible and 20 ft away. They choose a Magical check under current conditions, DC 12, before commitment. With Magical proficiency her combined bonus is +6. A roll of 7 gives 13. The diversion succeeds with the pre-agreed restriction: she keeps directing this channel until the worker crosses. There is no second purchase of Water I and no automatic d8 damage.

A COMPLETE ORDINARY ITEM

Canal hook. A Medium two-handed pole with a hook used to draw a rope closer or brace a light object. It has no extraordinary ingredient: Item BU 0, Load 2, final equipped requirement 2 slots. A carried spare still adds Load but uses no equipped slot. Its length gives no automatic Near Range permission for extraordinary workings.

Mira can carry and equip one hook: 2 of 55 Load and 2 of 6 equipped slots. Two hooks contribute 4 Load; equipping both requires 4 slots. Ordinary price and availability are setting decisions, not BU. A backpack organizes them without increasing capacity by default.

Example authored augmentation. “While this hook is equipped and braced on a stable support, add +2 to Prowess checks to hold a gate open.” Record a proposed Item BU price, such as 4, for review. The condition and check are exact; it neither increases Physical nor helps every attack. The hook’s two slots and Load 2 remain unless another explicit rule changes them. The augmented hook is a different item record, not a free benefit in the ordinary hook above.

Read a creature: canal watcher

Purpose. A river spirit guards a spawning bed beside a damaged sluice. It wants a safe flow, not slaughter. It warns anyone disturbing the gate and can negotiate if someone demonstrates a workable diversion.

Field	Complete example record
Chosen creature budget	25 BU; 20 acquired/spent; 5 remaining; no mirror credit
Foundation	Rank I; attribute points 3; Physical 2, Mental 0, Magical 1
Training	Proficient Magical; PB 2
Practices	Prowess/Finesse/Fieldcraft +2; Awareness/Reason/Knowledge/Influence +0; Mysticism/Communion/Intuition +3
Save bonuses	Physical +2; Mental +0; Magical +3 from the proficient attribute; no extra save-training grant
DC	5 + PB 2 + chosen Magical 1 = 8
Vitality	Maximum/current 13/13; unused short-rest allowance 7 if agreed rests apply
Size and mobility	Small; walking 25 ft; ordinary swim/climb 13 ft
Senses	Ordinary sight and hearing; no granted sense through walls
Items	None: Item BU 0; six equipment slots; carrying capacity 20 + 5 × 2 = 30

The baseline follows $r = \sqrt{25/25} = 1$; attribute points $\text{ceil}(3r) = 3$; PB $1 + \text{ceil}(r) = 2$; Vitality $\text{ceil}(25/2) = 13$. It uses the same fully stated Verb II, Water I, Near Range and d8 definitions as Mira, totaling 20 BU. It has no Knowledge proficiency purchase.

Turn the Current. A capability referencing Guided Water’s Verb II, Water I and Near Range ingredients. Redirect or reshape existing located water within 30 ft. State the actual path, volume, recipients and opposition before resolving. This does not automatically move a creature against its will; contest or another agreed resolution can be needed.

Water Impact. Uses those ingredients and d8 output to drive existing water into one located target within 30 ft. **Example normal expression:** 1d8 Magical Water damage, projected through the actual path. At

this table it uses an attack check with Magical training, +3, against the target's DC; it does not also demand a save by default. Appraise changed volume, recipients, timing or effort separately. This sample expression grants no healing, resistance or extra actions.

Behavior and tells. The Watcher points toward the spawning bed before attacking. It prefers turning the current to injuring people. It retreats or talks when the threat to the bed ends. A dry bank deprives it of useful existing water; its unused BU does not grant water creation, armor or teleportation.

In the digital creature editor, practice-allocation slices may be recorded as Physical Prowess 2/Finesse 0/Fieldcraft 0; Magical Mysticism 1/Communion 0/Intuition 0; Mental all 0. Those allocations satisfy its base ledger; the displayed checks still use the relevant full current attribute and applicable training, as listed above.

PROGRESS BEYOND LEVEL 21

Progression does not stop at level 20. Retain the published cumulative threshold at level 21, 286 BU. After that, add 10 each level and the subsequent four-level bracket spikes: +24 at level 25, +28 at 29, +32 at 33, continuing in that pattern. These are additions to the ordinary +10 at those levels. PB still follows $2 + \text{floor}((\text{level} - 1)/4)$.

Level	Cumulative BU	Baseline PB	Baseline maximum Vitality
22	296	7	374
23	306	7	391
24	316	7	408
25	350	8	450
26	360	8	468
29	418	9	551

Do not add a spike again to an already cumulative table value. Active PB and Vitality modifiers can change the resolved sheet.

MIRROR CREDIT WITHOUT ERASING THE DRAWBACK

Example, not a mandatory build. A level 1 character has 25 BU and spends 27 on positive acquisitions. An accepted eligible personal drawback supplies 2 credit, giving 25 net spent and 2 actual used debt. The level 1 debt ceiling is 4. The positive build is also below the next-level creation ceiling of 35. Review the drawback's actual rule and obtain the DM's agreement to exceed the ordinary allowance.

Having a ceiling of 4 does not mean the character automatically receives 4 credit. A character spending 23 has 2 ordinary BU remaining, even if the sheet also shows potential mirror headroom. A character proposing 31 positive

BU with only 2 valid credit remains 29 net spent: another 4 is not covered merely because a ceiling exists. Overflow still needs explicit agreement and must respect both applicable limits.

Compatible pairs are Add/Subtract, Multiply/Divide, Minimum/Maximum and Grant/Revoke. Set To has no automatic opposite. A personal drawback that revokes flight remains on that person; separately proposing flight for an ally does not repay or suppress it. A narrow condition or non-mirrorable rule must be respected.

AT THE TABLE: A QUICK REFERENCE

1. State an intent. Confirm ordinary circumstances and extraordinary access.
2. Locate the target or establish an authored alternative. Declare actual reach, recipients, output and duration.
3. Agree uncertainty, stakes, Cost and its timing. Revise the attempt if needed.
4. Resolve the chosen check, contest, clash, attack or save; apply bias and modifiers once.
5. Record changed positions, current Vitality, movement used, reactions, consequences and ongoing requirements.

Remember	Default or procedure
A check	d20 + current attribute + applicable training + modifiers
Trained / expert	PB / twice PB where actually granted
Bias	Cancel opposing stacks; N net stacks means N + 1 dice, keep appropriate extreme
Shared round	Council then Fast (0-1) then Measured (2-3) then Heavy (4+)
Reaction	One independent slot per round; valid trigger, immediate Complexity 0-1, self/touch or one target
Movement	One round allowance; split among tracks/reactions as the situation permits
Continuing work	One upkeep track per maintained capability; requirements of several capabilities accumulate
Damage defenses	Matching resistance half rounded up; vulnerability double; immunity zero
Collapse	Rescue promptly; stabilization stops dying but does not heal or wake
Short rest	Finite allowance $\text{ceil}(\text{max Vitality}/2)$; consume actual healing, carry unused recovery
Long rest	Agreed overnight recovery; normally full healing, refresh short-rest allowance
Purchases	Count acquisitions once; character BU, Item BU and execution Cost remain separate

GLOSSARY

Acquisition: an owned occurrence of a primitive, recorded in its ledger. References to it in several compositions are not extra purchases.

Attribute: Physical, Mental or Magical; use its current numerical value directly.

BU, Build Units: the acquisition measure. It is not automatically money, a spell resource or an encounter difficulty rating.

Capability: a working or talent organized from actual primitives, effects and readable rules.

Clash: a timing resolution when opposing intents meet; distinct from a contest of effort.

Complexity: the dependencies of an action, used in placing it in the shared rhythm; distinct from power or Strain.

Consequence: an actual change with a cause, applicable timing and ending/recovery terms.

Cost: the agreed pressure or consequence of an attempted execution; may be mechanical, restrictive, environmental or narrative.

Council: the coordination/continuation point at the beginning of a shared round.

DC: a difficulty target; a character's selected-attribute DC is distinct from their three saving throws.

Domain: the subject that an extraordinary permission can affect.

Effect: a reusable grouping of ingredients or outcomes; it is not an automatic new purchase.

Heritage: Lineage, Upbringing or Manifest: a narrative organization of actual acquired content.

Intent: the outcome an actor wants, stated before the resolution procedure is chosen.

Item BU: the separate acquisition accounting for equipment mechanics.

Load: carried burden; distinct from equipped slots, Item BU and ordinary value.

Mirror: an eligible reversed rule with actual scope and an accepted drawback; not an unrestricted cancellation trick.

PB: proficiency bonus. Apply applicable training once; expertise uses twice PB when granted.

Practice: an approach to a check associated with an attribute; ordinary attempts do not require training.

Primitive: a reusable permission or rule, with its own recipients, conditions and accounting.

Reaction: an immediate eligible response through an available independent slot and actual trigger.

Strain: contextual appraisal of how an attempt pushes the actor and situation, graded 0–6 as guidance.

Structure: the permitted arrangement of a working; it supplies no unrelated domain or verb access.

Template / play copy: a reusable creature definition / one independent creature's state in play.

Track: Fast, Measured or Heavy resolution timing in a shared round.

Upkeep: an agreed ongoing requirement of a maintained working; not necessarily damage.

Verb: the kind of change an extraordinary permission allows.

Vitality: current capacity to remain in action; its maximum and current value are separate.

credits, rights and edition

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Alpha status. This is a complete alpha publication, open to corrections and table feedback. One specific rule remains undecided: additional Vitality upkeep payments triggered by incoming damage, including its threshold and counter handling. It is visibly marked in the upkeep section. Other agreed upkeep requirements remain usable; this edition does not impose that unsettled numerical scheme.

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Use this alphabetical index for a rule, construction procedure or worked example. PDF page numbers and links refer to this edition; web links go directly to the section.

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